Matheism OMG: One Math God, I Am.

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Mathias the Matheist

Book 2: One Path

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The Call That Was Never Made

In the beginning, the end existed.

My friend Josh DM'd me: 'I'm so sorry.' I checked social media and found my last brother is gone from me. It was July 2nd, 2020. I told the friends with me. I was destroyed and didn't know what to do with my shattered self. I sought escape but couldn't wake from the nightmare. I flew back to LA. Byron was buried in the same cemetery as Guy. We had a funeral during the lockdown. I had not seen him in person for over a year. We had texted.

Byron had been building Everland with developers from his community. In a conversation with Dr. K, the psychiatrist Alok Kanojia, he said he was trying to give people something he had wanted as a kid. Dr. K connected that purpose with not wanting

others to feel alone. He had not finished the game.

Byron became Reckful, a world-champion gamer and pioneering streamer. In sixth grade he placed first nationally in private school math. In high school he won a national essay competition. He wrote about love. He was often cheery, loved photography, art, music, beauty, his friends, family, and good people. Thousands attended funerals across World of Warcraft servers, and millions mourned him online, on social media and in videos made about him.

Reckful said on stream that when he felt good, it did not matter to him that life has no bigger purpose. When the depression returned, it did not seem to matter what he thought. Ideas like matheist determinism, that he likely did not internalize, help dissolve thought loops. They do not fix all issues. A brain condition tortured my brothers, more than ideas and beliefs they lacked. Many live in fear of hell. At least they did not suffer that. Though they lived in it, bounded in time. Habits like social and physical activity outdoors help. Those were locked down for Byron in July 2020. That summer the CDC reported that one in four young adults had seriously considered suicide in the past month.

Twenty-five years earlier, my brother Guy also took his own life. He was twenty-one. He died four weeks after starting Prozac, nine years before the FDA's black-box warning that SSRIs, the antidepressant family that includes Prozac, can double the risk of suicidal thoughts and behavior in young people. At eleven he had flown out of Van Nuys. When I left for college, Byron took over my room as his computer room, where he gamed and later streamed, and almost ten years after Guy died, in high school, he made Guy's room next to it his bedroom. On the walls of that room, Guy had written out in his own hand the things that mattered to him: The map is not the territory. Life is not a problem to be solved but a reality to be experienced. Those who cling to life die. The truth of the thing is the feel of it not the think of it.

"Let it go." "When you're green you're growing. When you're ripe, you rot."

"The mind of a man is like a mirror." He struck out "it reflects the world" and wrote "or does it."

All that and more he wrote on his walls by twenty-one, by 1995. We drew on the walls too, like a mural, and wrote with paint. They were interesting things, not angry ones. He made them when he felt good, the way manic people can become artists.

To “Those who cling to life die,” I now add: all live, all die, forever remembering they’re one.

Guy was also a child prodigy. At eleven, the youngest pilot to fly from Van Nuys, the largest small-plane airport in the world. He grew to look better than Tom Cruise, with depth and intensity in his green eyes.

They suffered from manic depression, a genetic mental disorder in which about one in four attempt suicide. Byron was three to five times more likely to die after Guy did. The math of genetics and mind will cure what killed them.

I add: make the world reflect your mind. The delta between them is your vision, the work, the difference of destiny to be discovered.

My father Itamar searched too. His PhD thesis, The Delimitation of International Boundaries (Geneva, 1973, the year Guy was born), kept by nearly every country, argued the legal math of political structures. After Guy died, he kept writing, each work dissolving a different boundary. His novel The Star of Apocalypse blurred Judaism from Christianity through James, the brother of Jesus. In Distant Prophecies (2006) he told of Jeremiah, the fall of Jerusalem, and the temple burned, from whose ashes the

Bible was formed: destruction and creation, one act. My dad later wrote The Bone Box, a detective thriller on the real Yeshua family tomb found in Talpiot in 1980. Perhaps, in the end, he sought to resurrect Guy's ghost.

In Wreckful's Run, published November 2007, almost exactly midway between Guy's death in 1995 and Byron's in 2020, Bernstein prophesied the 2026 Iran War, 19 years later, complete with underground uranium recovery. In the fiction, its hero Avi "Wreckful" Inbar bombs Iran, Jesus is raised, with a character named Dani after Byron's middle name Daniel, and Israel as Truth's bride (Isaiah 62:5).

He imagined Byron's salvation before we'd know Byron's pain. His work was praised by James Tabor, Chair of Religious Studies at the University of North Carolina at Charlotte, who wrote him, "I have appreciated and learned from your work for several years now; you pick up on many things that others miss." Jack Kilmon, a biblical archaeology researcher who published with the Biblical Archaeology Society, praised it too.

I found their words in emails from the now closed Shilonites Yahoo group. Kilmon wrote that books like these do more than papers in obscure journals. In his words: "20 years from now, the

journals lay gathering dust and the papers not even footnotes, while elsewhere there will be archaeologists in the fields and professors in classrooms that had been set on their paths by the Bone Box or the Star of the Apocalypse.” It’s been exactly 20 years since the Bone Box was published in 2006. I’ve been set on one path to prove the resurrection of all.

Five works, five boundaries, one pattern. Nation/nation. Judaism/Christianity. Destruction/creation. Life/death. Past/future. Now I argue all boundaries are the eternal living math, and all math is boundaries.

In The Bone Box, a father describes finding his son. The father is my father. Two sentences from that passage have stayed with me. I mourned that part of myself which my son had reflected. I mourned for me. I wrote my own words about Guy in the weeks after he died. I was sixteen, and what I had was a song. It opened with the verses: Sitting in my room, staring at the carpet. I realize it’s full, of footsteps, memories. Of someone that used to love me. Now is gone from here. I came home and I saw, lights of ambulance and police. Right away I knew it. My brother is gone from me. When he died a crow came, and sat upon his tree.

It sat upon his tree. The chorus was a teenage cry of the kind that wears thin in adulthood but is the actual cry: God, why did you take away the one that I most loved? If you're all good and powerful, how could you let this be? Your apologies don't mean much to me. They won't change me at all.

Whatever strength you'll give will never compensate for the joy you took away. My father took the lyrics and put them in The Bone Box. The detective in the novel speaks them after losing his son. So the lyrics that Byron read at sixteen, when he edited The Bone Box for our father, and that he read aloud to his viewers less than a year before he died, contain the question the sixteen-year-old version of me was asking.

Byron and I shared an apartment in Marina del Rey, by Venice Beach, when he was eighteen and I was twenty-eight. We lived there together for about a year, into 2008. Then I left. I was twenty-nine. I took a break from working in tech and went traveling, then worked from the laptop. First the Brazilian coast for six months, then through Argentina. I came back to Los Angeles to chase the sun in forever summer when the global south became winter. Then I went out again. South America for another stretch, Chile, Peru, more of the southern coast. Then a cruise from the Caribbean to Mallorca, a small boat to Ibiza, a

three-day plan that became three years. Then all over Europe.

Russia and Ukraine. Israel. Jordan, the time I stopped over and went to Petra. Dubai. Bali. Over seventy countries across eighteen years, an odyssey of life, and more than a dozen I lived in long enough to feel at home. Byron stayed in the US. He moved from LA to Austin. He built his community on the streams.

To learn what the genre of online multiplayer games even was, we drove to a Fry's Electronics, they are gone now, and a salesman suggested Asheron's Call. It had just come out. We took it home. I played it for a while. Byron, who was ten, took it over. Within a year he could dodge against twenty people waiting at his portal-in point, casting spells through the dodging, and win. He never lost the gift. Everything that followed: the World of Warcraft dominance, the streaming, the community, the audience that would eventually mourn him by the millions, was downstream of a random suggestion in a since-defunct electronics store and a Pokemon online multiplayer game that I never made. He was famous, and increasingly alone underneath it.

I had told him I loved him in the way that brothers who have lived apart for a decade tell each other, which is to say, not often, and never with the knowledge I wish I had had that week. Earlier in

2020, in the months before he died, he had FaceTimed me. Byron looked happy. I told him I was with friends. He told me he loved me. He said: good, be with friends. He did not push me to come. That was the last time I saw him alive.

Twelve years of distance. This was more ruminated regret stacked atop grief. A thousand small choices and inactions, to not fly internationally to Austin during COVID lockdowns, to not bother him by calling. I carried this for almost four years. I had been somewhere else and didn't even know my brother was dying inside. I could not get over that, even though Byron never told me I should come visit.

I did not go looking for a picture of the world. The picture was what remained when grief collapsed the theater's illusion and I saw the matrix of causality in the world's scripted stage. The lights came up with the curtain. I saw the brick wall in the back. I saw things as they were. Not a single line or hair in the show could have been different. I unsuspended the disbelief that I could have been someone other than who I was. The loop that ran me, the grief and regret and shame and fear and the slow apathy underneath them, all of it rested on a single belief, and the belief was false. The illusion of an unmatrix outside fate is fuel for regret and grief.

What I Knew, and What I Felt

I had intellectually known about determinism most of my life. The laws of logic, before physics details, are what they are; the world unfolds per math; a chooser is part of that world, not a power outside it. The term free-will is itself a square-circle.

I had known this, that all is math, by the time I was ten. I bought an 8-inch Celestron telescope with money from working in my father's office, read Einstein's popular account of relativity, and concluded, in the way a ten-year-old concludes things, that the night sky and the equations and my own thoughts were the same kind of thing. I had carried this for decades without it ever helping. I had been able to say it out loud. Knowing something intellectually and knowing it in the way that changes how you feel are different operations.

For me, the pressure was the years after Byron died. The intellectual knowledge was old. The lived knowledge arrived in April 2024, in a kitchen, on an otherwise ordinary morning. I had taken a year of the hardest calculus-based physics track at the University of California, Santa Barbara as part of a computer science degree, 20 years earlier, enough to feel comfortable with

the field and learn more on my own.

When I wanted to understand something, I could. In a rotational physics calculus class, I did no homework the entire trimester, only attended lectures, studied three days before the final, and aced the test. Same story in theory of computation. The next class I failed because I slept through all lectures, all at 8 am, did no homework, and didn’t even study for the exam, and it turns out that not every subject in electrical circuits and waves was perfectly intuitive to me, especially when I didn’t read the instructions.

My attention works in bursts. I have to write what I think the moment I think it, or it’s gone in seconds, replaced by the next original thought. The ideas lead to each other, often across completely different fields, but I forget the bridge that connected them even as the next one arrives. The weaker short-term memory may even fuel the creativity, forcing fresh directions. What I have is the curiosity, confidence and audacity that my perception, creativity and imagination can find the one truth, the rational answer and logical proof of math’s fundamental reality in a supernatural believing nonsense world of emperors with no clothes.

The burning desire for expansion and success burns hottest when you focus on what is most important. That is Matheism. Beyond that, creating superintelligence, bringing Eden to Earth, which I have already begun training my mind on. Bringing Matheists together in discovering and creating complexity, the order and chaos of life, with gratitude across spacetime. To be fruitful and multiply.

In the years since, I had read physics the way an interested adult reads physics he had been thinking about since he was a child. I remember reading Hofstadter's Gödel, Escher, Bach and Gleick's Chaos around the same time as my physics courses, both done the old way: sitting with a long, complicated book for days or weeks. The work I was doing in 2023 and 2024 happened at a different pace, because I had changed how I took information in.

The kind of mind I have processes in bursts, it forgets quickly and generates new ideas faster than the input can land. Compressed input, rapid cross-referencing, and the ability to interrogate what I was hearing in real time changed how I could work. With Audible I could absorb the physicist Sabine Hossenfelder's Existential Physics in three hours while playing a game or doing chores. It's excellent, except for calling mathematical monism (the view that all of reality is mathematical) Platonism. Plato separates forms

from the world; Matheism identifies the structure with the thing itself.

I came across Tegmark's Mathematical Universe Hypothesis. The response I had was not learning but recognition: yes, that. I knew it could be improved into a logical proof, not his mere hypothesis. The computer scientist Jürgen Schmidhuber's December 1996 manuscript, published in 1997, already considered all computable universes and used algorithmic information, the length of the shortest program producing each one, to weigh possibilities. His later speed prior also counted computational cost. Tegmark mapped the territory. Schmidhuber worked on the measure. Neither proved it had to be so.

I was also, around then, listening to someone talk about free will. I do not remember what tipped me into actually hearing it that morning instead of dismissing it. Something tipped. I was sitting in Byron's old chair, looking at the toy house he played on as a boy, my mind uniting streams of consciousness across time like steam swirling in a tea ceremony.

Not even a hair could have been different. The thing I had known intellectually for 30 years was suddenly the thing I knew with my whole body. There was no alternative path.

The first response was cold. The first feeling was that everything I cared about had been pulled away from a center I had been imagining was holding it together. For about a day I went around in a kind of mild dissociation. The world looked slightly thinner. The colors were the colors but they were also, somehow, behind glass. It was not a spiritual event followed by a mathematical confirmation. It was a mathematical event that felt like the mind coming together. The feeling and the proof are not two things. They never were.

Then the cold warmed into something else. I went for a walk. I had the kind of luck of living near hills, in a quiet verdant neighborhood where you could step out the front door and be in the trails within five minutes. It was spring, near Byron’s birthday on May 8. The hills were green. The wildflowers were out. I walked for a couple of hours. What I felt, walking, was gratitude.

I had music in my headphones during part of the walk. I searched for gratitude and found a cover by a hillside recording. It was a Jesus song. The words were about being grateful. They called me to more than accept creation and reality as it is, given nothing could have been different. That fit what I was feeling, and the music fit the morning. What I had been resisting, for years, was the recognition that the structure of the world was sufficient. That

nothing outside it was missing.

That the brothers I loved were located and not lost because there was no other place they could be. The structure that contained the moments when my brothers were alive was the same structure that contained me, walking in the hills on an April morning, feeling something close to peace for the first time since 2020. I came to a phrase, in the weeks after that walk, that I have used since to describe what had happened. White light through a prism of minds. The world is one light. Each of us is one prism. The colors that come out are different through every prism. The light is the same light. When you stop pretending the colors are the light, the colors get easier and the light gets closer.

The Counterfactual Machine

In the complete history I am arguing for, nothing could have been otherwise. Internalizing that is a different universe than intellectually knowing it. We are free to choose, but the choices are all determined in the block universe of math’s causality, where past, present and future all exist at once.

Libertarian free will, the belief that our choices are not fixed by prior causes, is the biggest lie of supernatural irrational religion:

there cannot be an agent or randomness that is not causal and also you. This is impossible and logically incoherent, like square circles, whereas any claim in mythology is merely extremely unlikely and dubious. All is ruled or random and both are math. I came to call this the rules-random dichotomy, or RRD. For anything to interact with the structure of math that is all of physics, it has to also be math and causal, including consciousness.

All the frames are already there, wound around a spool in a metal can. The beginning, middle, and end exist at once as a sequence of images. But there is no projector outside the universe moving a light along the film. The observer and the memories that distinguish one frame from the next belong inside it.

When an author finishes a book, every chapter is set. The characters' choices are fixed on the page. Yet those choices are still real within the story. That the author is not surprised by them does not make them less meaningful to the characters.

Another timeline does not change this one. Responsibility remains in the consequences, reflection, and correction.

Reckful called them thought loops. He described them on stream as an icy mountain with sleds: grooves the mind falls into, the

same path every time, no way to steer. The should-have and if-only carved the same grooves into ice. Matheism melted mine away because they were not real. The real grooves are destiny. My path was the only path. I was freed. I exist, because I am patterned. To be is not to be random. I was what I was. I am that I am.

Knowing that the loop is unhelpful did not stop it. Some part of me still believed the other branch had been mine to take. That was the suspicion I had to examine. Regret becomes a kind of private science fiction, a multiverse of selves who did better than I did. Every memory became evidence for the prosecution in a trial I was running against myself.

The Whole History

The block-universe reading of relativity treats the complete spacetime history as one structure. Relativity supplies no observer-independent simultaneity for all distant events. The claim that the whole history is equally real is the interpretation I use here. It gives the grief a different picture of where the people I loved are. In that picture, what is real is the whole. Past, present, and future, all of them, exist equally. The universe is a four-dimensional block, and we move through it the way a finger

moves along a recording. The recording is not being made. It already is. We are reading it.

The picture says only that all of those events, taken together, form one timeless whole, and the sense of motion through them is what some of those events feel like from inside, not a separate clock outside the history. Eternal existence does not require an infinite past. A complete mathematical history can have a first event while the whole history exists timelessly. In the account developed here, time is sequential production from a beginning; that premise is distinct from mathematical eternity, and the beginning need not be the hot Big Bang. Einstein expressed a related consolation. In 1955, his oldest friend Michele Besso died.

Besso and Einstein had walked home from work together at the Bern patent office for years, and Besso had been one of the few people Einstein had bounced relativity off as he was developing it. Einstein wrote a condolence letter to Besso’s family. For us believing physicists, Einstein wrote, the distinction between past, present, and future is only a stubbornly persistent illusion. He died four weeks later.

I can visit Byron and Guy in my mind. Their unique laughs, how they were, and were loved. We can visit those outside our time, in our minds. All moments are eternal. We're all in all of them forever.

What stopped when Byron died was not the structure. The structure is still there, at his coordinates in the block, as permanent as any mathematical fact. What stopped was the transitioning: the processing, the modeling, the feeling. Consciousness is what transitions feel like from inside a self-modeling structure. When the transitions stop, the consciousness stops. The structure that held the transitions does not. Byron's transitions are still in the block where they happened. The structure of the moments when he was alive includes the transitioning he was. I can return to those moments in memory. They have not gone anywhere.

Spinoza's eternity is not a longer life after this one. It is existence understood without duration. His eternal mind is not the promise of another morning with all your memories intact. My account of Byron's moments in the block is a different argument. The kinship is that permanence need not mean continuing forever.

The Blessing Is the Memory

In the block mathverses, my brothers aren't gone. Their patterns persist eternally. Guy at eleven, flying both toy and real planes. Living together. Our family trip driving to Yosemite and across America. Bike rides through Venice Beach. Taking Byron to college. Playing music, guitar, Nintendo, Doom, Heroes, Civilization, Age of Empires, Final Fantasy, Secret of Mana, Zelda, Starlink, Asheron's Call and WoW side by side. Every stream Reckful did, every joke he made, every moment of connection with his community: permanent as the number 3. A hologram doesn't disappear from time when you look away, from different angles. All lives are already completed. The moments when we live exist, permanently, in the structure, as children of the light. Zichronam livracha. The blessing is the memory.

Reflection and Correction

I should have acted on what I saw with Guy. I should have seen it with Byron. I should have done so many things differently.

The answer is that there is one path. Not one path that was chosen well or badly, but one, the only one the arithmetic permitted, and what I knew and what I did were both part of that path. The guilt is real and it is a claim about a road that was never

there.

There is a difference between remorse and resentment toward your past self. Remorse says, what happened was harmful. I will act differently when similar patterns arise. Resentment says, I should have been a different person than the one I was. The first fits the structure. The second is a square circle. Taking responsibility means reflection and correction.

The lie is not that I failed them. The lie is that things could have been otherwise. It is beyond forgiveness. There is nothing to forgive. You do not forgive the rain. You never blamed the inevitable physics of nature in the first place.

I had not acted on what I saw. I usually have optimism and plans for great things. I also came to accept otherwise without losing vitality, because all is destiny. Knowing that the past could not have gone otherwise says nothing whatever about the next hour, which has not happened yet and which you are the mechanism of. You are how it unfolds. So do the best available thing, now, with what you have, and keep doing it.

A common misunderstanding: if everything is determined, why bother? Because the bothering is one of the determinations. Your bothering is part of the path. If you do not bother, the path is one

without your bothering, and the structure is poorer for it.

The self-flagellation and rumination only ended when I internalized destiny, and got back up, moving forward, one step after the other.

The same mistake turns outward. Someone else succeeds and becomes the explanation for everything you failed to do. Real obstacles exist. So do corruption, exclusion and ordinary bad luck. Name them precisely enough to act on them.

Blaming Jews as a hidden collective power does the opposite: it replaces a cause you can investigate with an enemy that explains everything. Your work is not outside destiny. It is one of the ways destiny happens. Study what works. Build what you can. Another people’s achievement is not your dispossession, and envying their agency does not exercise yours.

They are patterns in the same structure. Damaging one of them is the structure damaging itself. Helping one of them is the structure repairing itself. They are you. So love your neighbor as yourself, because you are every stranger, the same one self. But put your gas mask on first to help others.

The Three Stages

Stage one is fusion. Religion, the naive self. You ARE your thoughts. Your anger is you. Your fear is you. No separation, no perspective, no peace. Eden before the fruit. Wholeness without understanding.

Stage two is separation. Mindfulness says: notice you are the stillness at the bottom of a lake, and thoughts and their corresponding emotions are separate, ripples at the surface. Zen says: you are not your thoughts. Post-structuralism says: signs refer to signs, with no ground. All three achieve the same move: the self-model is seen as separate from the self. This is liberating. It is also cold. Anyone who has practiced may have noticed: a calm disembodiment, a clarity that lacks wholeness, alive but not fully alive. The dark night of the meditator.

The meditative and mystical is anti-mystical: the practice designed to unite you with the divine separates you from it, because the divine IS the self. The monkey mind of thought divides ourselves from our one self. Quieting the monkey mind is the path back, not transcending the self. For trauma, the separation can be a necessary first step: distance from overwhelming emotion is therapeutic. Yet the severed bicameral mind is definitionally disunited, lacking oneness and the enjoyment of undivided engagement, in the zone and warmth of

feeling and acting fully aligned, of being whole.

Post-structuralism collapsed here entirely, because signs without ground felt like nothing is real. Derrida saw the recursion and called it groundless. Zen reaches satori and stops. Tolle describes the state without completing the return. In one talk he calls the consciousness in which perception happens nobody's: it is the one. He still sees two dimensions, form and the formless.

Buddhism calls life suffering, empty, unsatisfying, and prescribes escape from the cycle of rebirth. The bodhisattva delays his own liberation to help others leave samsara. But nirvana outside samsara is an unmatrix outside creation. Mathematical structure is all there is. There is no outside to escape to. Buddhism claims non-duality while positing the oldest dualism: a place beyond this place. The compassion is real. The exit is not. Alan Watts read the bodhisattva without an exit. A first taste of deep wisdom can sap the will: if all is well anyway, why build anything? Stop there and you are a pratyekabuddha, a buddha for himself alone. The bodhisattva comes back into everyday life, because the others are you, nerve ends of one body.

The most sophisticated Buddhists saw through it. Nagarjuna, the second-century founder of Madhyamaka philosophy, argued in

the *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā*, his Root Verses on the Middle Way, that there is no distinction whatsoever between samsara and nirvana. If all phenomena lack inherent existence, then samsara has no inherent nature to escape from. The boundary between the cycle and its cessation is itself empty. Buddhism's most sophisticated philosopher closed the exit door from the inside eighteen centuries ago. Matheism proves it; all is a monist matrix of all we could possibly imagine.

The coldness is structural. Stage two creates a new dualism: the unfelt witness watching the felt thoughts. But if the witness were truly unfelt, you could not report it. You could not sense the stillness. You could not say "I feel peaceful." The sensing of stillness is itself a felt transition. The lake bottom is also feeling. Otherwise it doesn't exist. This is the philosophical zombie argument, about a being that acts like us but feels nothing, applied to the meditator's witness. A non-feeling witness that reports feeling is a contradiction. The witness is felt. The watched is felt. Both feeling feelings. Two hands drawing each other. One lake.

Stage three is reunion. Not the fusion of stage one, where self and model were undifferentiated. Not the separation of stage two, where one watches the other from behind glass. Recognition.

The self and the self-model are one structure that was always one. Philo, a Jewish contemporary of Jesus, interpreted Genesis the same way: the first creation, “in God’s image,” was the undivided human, pre-gender, pre-categorical. Male and female was the second creation, the divided one. Yeshua in the Gospel of Thomas tells Mary to suppress her gender identification to recognize her essential humanity: not because women are lesser, but because mathematical structure has no gender. The undivided is the first creation. The reunion of stage three recovers it.

Developmental psychology maps the same arc. Ken Wilber’s integral model tracks nine levels of cognition, from stimulus-response through tribal myth, rational science, postmodern relativism, and integral understanding, to the ninth: the witness watching its own watching. Matheism is Level 9 and beyond. It gives the witness what it was witnessing: one math, one self, the ground the spotlight always stood on.

Eden was stage one: naive unity. Exile was stage two: knowledge of good and evil, the separation, the cold clarity. Everland is stage three: return to unity, knowing. The tree of knowledge didn’t curse you. It was the middle step. The Pythagoreans said all is number. Legend says they drowned

Hippasus for revealing irrational numbers, which no fraction can equal. The irony: irrational numbers completed the thesis. The most irreducible number is the simplest self-reference. The heresy was the orthodoxy.

After the Loop

Mine was instantaneous, in one sense. The recognition that there really was no other option happened all at once, and once it had happened it could not be unrecognized. What took months, what is still unfolding two years later, is what it is to live inside the recognition. That part was not what I expected. I had thought, in advance, that if I really came to believe the argument, I would feel cold.

That was not what happened, except for the first day or two, when the cold was real but turned out to be a passage rather than a destination. What happened, on the other side of the cold, was harder to name.

The grief was still there. The love was still there. The wish that things had been different had stopped being a wish for something that could have been, and started being a wish for something that could not have been. A wish for what cannot be hurts less. It is

less convertible into self-attack. I would walk in the hills at sunrise, listening to Alan Watts, who brought Eastern philosophy to the West. In my head, often, was the old Jewish hymn Adon Olam: Eternal Master, before any creature was created.

What replaced it became the bliss Eckhart Tolle writes about in The Power of Now, and that Watts had circled in his lectures: a kind of widened presence, less narrowed, less defended. I had visited that territory before, years earlier. I had not had the language for it. Now I have Matheism beyond those that I'm called to teach; to spread its light. I enjoyed doing any ordinary thing. Or doing nothing. Just breathing and walking upright felt like being the entire universe, without need of anything. The grooves in the ice had begun to soften. The present got bigger. When I stopped demanding a different past I had a lot more attention left over for what was actually in front of me.

I started doing ordinary things again. Walking in the hills without an internal monologue. Sitting in the yard. Swimming. Just being where I was. The world, which had felt sticky and gray for years, began to recover its color. Not because the grief was over. Because I could remember them with joy and not only loss. What surprised me most was that the people I had lost felt closer rather than further. The block universe has a quiet effect on the

relationship to the dead that I had not anticipated. The moments when Byron was alive are not behind me. They are in the structure.

It is not happening now. There are infinite worlds where every possible mind and memory watches the life of every other. All of them are you: the one self from different perceptions. They are as you were and will be. After we die, we live on forever as everyone, the way we are now. Where were you before you were born? Alan Watts set two statements side by side: after I die, I shall be reborn as a baby and forget my former life; after I die, a baby will be born. They say the same thing.

When the rumination starts, I return to the claim inside it. The version of me I imagine was never available in this history. I can learn from what happened without spending the rest of my life demanding a different past. That was the move that helped me. The grief is not a failed argument.

Spinoza saw it in his Ethics: “the pain arising from the loss of any good is mitigated, as soon as the man who has lost it perceives, that it could not by any means have been preserved.” Speaking about a loss helps when it puts it in order; too much of it is rumination, solidifying an identity in pain and loss. The body

keeps the score, so shake it off and move on. Acknowledge the pain to the extent that's helpful and not beyond. As Dr. Phil said at the UN, "how long you grieve and how deeply you hurt is not a mirror to how much you loved." There is no obligation to wallow in pain or self-pity, or to feed the pain body that wants it to continue.

As nothing could have been otherwise, is anything anyone's fault? No, but the justice system still needs to punish and deter. Ethics is not dissolved, but you are forgiven because there is no cosmic guilt in destiny. It is beyond forgiveness. You do not blame the rain for the inevitable laws of nature. Consequences and corrective reflection teach and protect, but rumination destroys. I accept the past, present and future, and forgive myself and all, because a trial of destiny is a rejection of inevitable existence.

The grief that held me in the loop became my calling: to spread the light, and wrestle for truth.

End of Book 2. Next, Book 3: Wrestle for Truth. Get all 7 in 1 at matheism.org